AET6005 Digital Learning Platforms

Design Proposal

Gamification in ELICOS

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Executive Summary

ELICOS teachers work in one of the most demanding language teaching environments in Australia, where cultural diversity, high learner turnover, and intensive timetables make sustained student engagement a genuine daily challenge. Gamification is well established as an effective tool for addressing this, with systematic reviews confirming consistent gains in motivation, participation, and language outcomes across proficiency levels. Yet despite the evidence, no practical, ELICOS-specific framework exists to help teachers use it.

This proposal outlines the design of a blended learning solution that closes that gap. Grounded in Action Mapping, the solution consists of an e-learning module that builds foundational knowledge, followed by a synchronous digital workshop where participants move from categorising and selecting mechanics to designing and defending a classroom-ready gamified activity.

The target audience spans three career stages, from early career teachers to senior coordinators, each with distinct barriers and learning needs. The solution is designed to be immediately applicable, practically grounded, and respectful of the professional expertise participants bring with them.

Instructional Design Model

Action Mapping (Moore, n.d.) starts with a measurable performance goal and works backwards, identifying the actions learners must be able to perform, then designing practice for those actions, and including only the information those activities require. Content that doesn't serve a specific action gets cut.

For this solution, the goal is unambiguous: teachers apply gamification mechanics to their existing materials on the spot. On their way to that goal, learners move from understanding the evidence, to categorising and selecting mechanics, to applying them under realistic conditions, to justifying their decisions to peers. The sequence is deliberate. Each stage builds the capability the next one demands.

Needs Assessment

It's 3pm on a Thursday. You've just finished an intensive grammar session. The room is quiet, unfocused, and just flat. You've already used your best warmer, the pair work landed with a thud, and the gap-fill you pulled from the coursebook is doing what gap-fills always do at 3pm on a Thursday. You change the task. Same energy. You know the lesson isn't bad. You just don't have anything left in the kit that's built for this moment.

This is not a personal failure. It is a design problem.

Gamification works in ESL and EFL classrooms. Systematic reviews drawing on a combined 70 studies confirm consistent gains in motivation, participation, and language outcomes across proficiency levels (Zhang & Hasim, 2023; Chan & Lo, 2024).

Knowing gamification works and knowing how to use it are two different things. A systematic review of university educators' perspectives found that lack of time, lack of training, and uncertainty about methodology were the most consistently reported barriers to gamification adoption, with even those who held positive attitudes toward the approach still encountering significant design-related and administrative obstacles (Lester et al., 2023). The solution the authors recommend is direct: targeted professional development that gives educators the practical tools to implement gamification in their teaching context (Lester et al., 2023, p. 1766).

The evidence for gamification in ESL and EFL classrooms is not in dispute. What is missing is the bridge between that evidence and classroom practice. A review of 138 presentations across nine English Australia PD Fest programmes in Victoria, New South Wales, and Queensland from 2023 to 2025 found zero sessions addressing gamification directly, while AI dominated the agenda with approximately 35 to 40 dedicated sessions (English Australia, 2023a, 2023b, 2023c, 2024a, 2024b, 2024c, 2025a, 2025b, 2025c). ELICOS teachers are not being given the tools to use what the research already supports.

The learning gap this solution is designed to close is precise: ELICOS teachers need a practical, context-specific framework for selecting and applying gamification mechanics to their existing activities, and no such resource currently exists within the sector's professional development landscape.

Target Audience

The primary audience for this workshop is Australian ELICOS teachers, professionals working in a sector defined by cultural diversity, high learner turnover, and the constant pressure to keep language learning engaging. Unlike generalist educators, ELICOS teachers work at the intersection of language acquisition, intercultural communication, and real-world student outcomes, making the quality and variety of their classroom activities directly consequential.

This workforce spans a wide range of experience levels, from early career teachers still building their repertoire, to mid-career specialists navigating the demands of academic English, to senior coordinators responsible for the PD culture of their entire centre. They share a commitment to student engagement, but their relationship to gamification and the barriers preventing them from using it differs significantly across career stages.

The personas that follow represent three points in this audience. They are shaped by differences in career stages, classroom demands and learning preferences.

Persona 1: Early Career

BD

Becky D.

ELICOS Teacher · Pre-Intermediate (A2) · Age 22
CELTA + Bachelor of Arts

Early career **Tech confident** **Activity Focused**

CAREER TIMELINE

BEFORE TEACHING
3 years part-time retail while completing university

YEARS 1–2 TEACHING
ELICOS Melbourne, A1–B2 classes across levels

CURRENTLY
Teaching pre-intermediate while building confidence and activity repertoire

GOALS

For her teaching
Keeping students engaged across a full lesson, even when energy drops

For her colleagues
Being able to communicate ideas and challenges effectively

For herself
Feel confident that her lesson plan is going to work, but have options when it doesn't

SKILLS

- A fresh perspective
- High energy
- Tech fluency
- Learner relatability
- Thorough Planning
- Pop Culture Awareness

ATTITUDES & PREFERENCES

Learning style
Inductive: do first, understand why second

Device
Phone-first and comfortable with digital tools

Social
Likes to talk through her ideas to get reassurance

PAINS	LEARNING NEEDS
Disengaged learners	Gamification mechanics that re-engage a flat room without derailing the lesson plan
Narrow activity repertoire and relies on the same formats	A gamification framework she can apply across different situations
Unsure what works and lacks confidence to trust her instincts	Activities with clear, trackable engagement markers so she can see what's working

LEARNING CHALLENGES

Cognitive overload
Too much theory too fast causes disengagement

Authentic grounding
Abstract PD concepts don't stick without clear classroom examples

Intimidation
May feel apprehensive about contributing ideas in collaborative tasks

Persona 2: Mid-Career

DT

Danny T.

ELICOS Teacher · EAP · Age 29

BA Linguistics · DELTA (in progress)

Mid-career **Academic specialist** **Tech confident**

CAREER TIMELINE

YEARS 1–2
Primary school, China
High-energy and game-heavy

YEARS 3–7
ELICOS, Brisbane, B1 through Academic

CURRENTLY
Teaching EAP while completing DELTA

GOALS

For his teaching
Be holistic in his delivery while respecting the curriculum

For his colleagues
Provide research-based and experience-based ideas, insights and support

For himself
DELTA completion and to move toward a head teacher role

SKILLS

- Cross-level experience
- Dynamic response to student feedback
- Builds rapport quickly
- Theoretical curiosity
- Deep grammatical theory
- Organised

ATTITUDES & PREFERENCES

Learning style
Theory first, then application so he can validate his instinct through research

Prior knowledge
Wants it acknowledged and built upon, not replaced

Tech
High confidence personally, but prefers paper-based delivery in class to maintain integrity

PAINS	LEARNING NEEDS
Received feedback that he teaches too much from the book, but the curriculum is non-negotiable	Techniques for adapting the book and curriculum elements into games and activities
Games feel like they sit outside the schedule rather than inside it	Low-prep mechanics that fit within existing lesson time without eating into curriculum coverage
High expectations + heavy curriculum leave little room to experiment	Low-risk ways to experiment within the curriculum without it feeling like a detour

LEARNING CHALLENGES

Time poor
Limited time due to marking load and personal commitments

Context legitimacy
Needs to understand the ‘power’ of play in the classroom

Objection management
Will disengage if content feels irrelevant, is delivered poorly, or underestimates his experience

Persona 3: Senior Coordinator

LM

Linda M.

Director of Studies · Age 52
MEd · 25+ years in education

Senior **Servant leadership style** **Conference regular** **Occasional cover teacher**

CAREER TIMELINE

YEARS 1–10
Classroom teacher, All CEFR levels
Built deep understanding for what works across learner types

YEARS 11–20
MEd completed
Began mentoring colleagues and speaking at PD conferences

CURRENTLY
Director of Studies, Sydney
Supports teachers, reacts to student complaints, reports to the CEO
Occasionally needs to cover classes

GOALS

For her staff
Give teachers a practical, research-backed toolkit they can use

For herself
Stay current, and walk into a cover class feeling like herself again

For the centre
Justify the investment to the CEO with measurable teacher and student outcomes

SKILLS

- Deep theoretical knowledge
- Cross-level teaching experience
- Inclusive
- Institutional authority to implement change
- Aware of current trends
- Adaptive

ATTITUDES & PREFERENCES

Grounding
Deeply theoretical, wants research citations she can reference

Engagement
Loves to feel excited

Value Based
Will prioritise if the value is clear upfront

PAINS	LEARNING NEEDS
Needs to justify the PD investment to the CEO with something measurable	Research-backed evidence plus observable classroom outcomes she can report upward
Student complaints require responsive, documented action	A framework she can point teachers to immediately
Cover teaching often leaves minimal planning time	Gamification mechanics that will work across any situation she might walk into

LEARNING CHALLENGES

Servant first
Will deprioritise her own learning unless framed as benefiting her staff

Value threshold
Must see clear relevance quickly or won't invest time on faith alone

Consolidation
Rich prior knowledge but needs content that honours it rather than repeats it

Learning Objectives

This workshop gives teachers the ability to pick up any activity and turn it into a game on the spot. The objectives below describe what that looks like in practice. By the end of this blended learning experience, participants will be able to:

1. **Explain** the research evidence for gamification in ESL/EFL contexts, referencing at least two peer-reviewed findings, to justify its use to students, colleagues and institutional decision-makers. *(Bloom's Level 2 — Understand)*

2. **Categorise** a set of gamification mechanics according to their application in common ELICOS classroom situations, including warmers, skill-focused tasks, and consolidation activities. Thus, demonstrating how context shapes mechanic selection. *(Bloom's Level 4 — Analyse)*

3. **Justify** mechanic placements using evidence-based reasoning and evaluate the choices of peers, acknowledging that multiple valid configurations exist depending on context. *(Bloom's Level 5 — Evaluate)*

4. **Design** a gamified classroom activity using existing teaching materials, incorporating a minimum of two mechanics, a clear learning goal, and simple instructions ready for immediate classroom use. *(Bloom's Level 6 — Create)*

These objectives move participants from understanding the evidence to creating a classroom-ready product — building confidence, providing a defensible framework, and delivering practical outcomes regardless of career stage.

Curriculum Design

<table>
<tr><th></th><th>LO 1
Explain the evidence</th><th>LO 2
Categorise mechanics</th><th>LO 3
Justify and evaluate</th><th>LO 4
Design an activity</th></tr>
<tr><td rowspan="2">Learning Theory</td><td>Cognitivism</td><td colspan="2" rowspan="2">Constructivism</td><td>Constructivist-Constructionist Learning</td></tr>
<tr><td>Connectivism</td><td>Andragogy</td></tr>
<tr><td rowspan="3">Instructional Strategies</td><td>Direct Instruction</td><td colspan="2">Collaborative Learning</td><td rowspan="2">Personalisation and Differentiation</td></tr>
<tr><td>Flipped Classroom</td><td colspan="2">Game-Based Learning and Gamification</td></tr>
<tr><td>Use of Multimedia</td><td colspan="2">Active Learning</td><td>Feedback and Assessment</td></tr>
<tr><td>Assessment</td><td colspan="2">Formative Assessment</td><td colspan="2">Authentic Assessment</td></tr>
<tr><td rowspan="2">Activities</td><td>E-learning module
Individual · module · learner-led</td><td>Timed sorting activity
Small groups · workshop · student-led</td><td>Convergence task
Whole class · workshop · student-led</td><td>Individual creation task
Individual · workshop · student-led</td></tr>
<tr><td>Opening discussion
Whole class · workshop · teacher-led</td><td>Collaborative sorting task
Small groups · workshop · student-led</td><td>Peer defence
Whole class · workshop · teacher-facilitated</td><td>Gallery and feedback
Whole class · workshop · teacher-facilitated</td></tr>
</table>

The curriculum follows the logic of Action Mapping, with each activity building the capability the next one demands. The e-learning module provides the conceptual foundation, and the workshop progresses from categorising mechanics in small groups through to designing and defending an original gamified activity. Cognitivism, constructivism, connectivism, and andragogy are matched to these stages, ensuring the design is both rigorous and respectful of participants' professional experience. Assessment is formative throughout.

Conclusion

ELICOS teachers already know engagement matters. This solution gives them the tools to do something about it. Grounded in Action Mapping and designed around three detailed learner personas, the blended learning experience moves participants from understanding the evidence base, through categorising and selecting mechanics, to designing and defending a classroom-ready gamified activity.

The curriculum is built on a simple principle: every activity exists because a later one requires it. The result is a solution that is practically grounded, theoretically coherent, and immediately usable. The learning gap it closes is real, the need is documented, and the design is ready.

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